

☒ ~~My portfolio is ready to be reviewed.~~

School Name: Hawaii Academy of Arts and Science

Student Name: Samuel Carlos

Course Name: **Four Habits of Powerful Teaching and Learning:
The Neuroscience behind effective instruction
Habit #1: Ready to Learn**

To earn PDE3 Credit for this course you will do the following:

- Review the PDE3 Reflection/Portfolio Guidelines in this document
- Complete all assignments in the Ready to Learn Course in Canvas
- **Submit Portfolio for Review in Canvas: September 2nd, 2024**
- **Revisions to Portfolio Due in Canvas: September 16th, 2024**

This portfolio should:

- ❑ be an episode of your learning
- ❑ clearly capture and portray your growth, integration & learning to be able to cause student learning through the acquisition of knowledge, skills, & dispositions
- ❑ have a clear focus on interpreting student results and making connections to teacher actions, instructional strategies, curriculum materials, etc.
- ❑ include reflections that summarize the documents in the portfolio and trace how the documents and the training activity have captured and portrayed growth, integration, and learning
- ❑ include captions that transform documents into evidence and assist teacher in articulating their thoughts regarding improvements in standards-based instruction
- ❑ include professional development goals and objectives that are aligned to the professional development activities that will impact the professional growth of the teacher and impact student learning

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Participant Agreements

- ✓ I have read the “How to Write the Captions” and “How to Write a Reflection” pages.
- ✓ I agree to submit all assignments and peer feedback by the scheduled due dates.
- ✓ I agree to successfully complete all assignments and activities PRIOR to submitting my portfolio.
- ✓ I agree to complete my portfolio and revisions on time.
- ✓ I agree to turn in my own work (no plagiarism).
- ✓ I agree to ensure each response is unique and relevant to the question.
- ✓ I agree to actively participate in CANVAS discussions and activities.
- ✓ I agree to respond to professors in a timely manner (course communication: CANVAS discussions, email or phone call).
- ✓ I understand that if I wait until the last minute to complete my portfolio, I run the risk of not earning the 3 PD credits.

Signature

Date:

Instructions For Signature:

1. Click Insert -> Drawing -> New
2. Change the line tool option to “Scribble.”
3. Sign your name using the trackpad or mouse.
4. Press “Save and Close” and drag the signature to the line above.

How to Write a Reflection

Reflection provides teachers an opportunity to summarize the documents in the portfolio and show how the documents capture change and growth in them and in their students. It allows teachers to deeply examine their practice & allows others to examine the thinking behind the teaching documented in the portfolio.

Think about the following questions in order to help you refine your reflections:

- *What happened?* Begin by simply writing down what happened without jumping to analysis or judgment. This involves creating a brief narrative of the portfolio documents and of the training activity. Only then can the second step be addressed.
- *Why did it happen?* Attempting to understand why an event happened the way it did is the beginning of reflection. Search the context within which the event occurred for explanations. Consider underlying structures within the school that may be part of the event and examine deeply held values. More questions than answers may surface. Answer the questions in a way that make sense to you. Reflection often stops here; however, more in-depth searching is needed. The search for meaning is step three.
- *What might it mean?* Reflection is a way to find meaning. It is only through reflection that we recognize we had choices, that we could have done something differently. Recognizing that there is no one answer is an important step. Explore possible meanings rather than determine the meaning. But understanding by itself does not create changes in classroom practice. The last step involves holding our practices to the light of those new understandings.
- *What are the implications of my practice?* Consider how your practice might change given any new understandings that have emerged from the earlier steps. What new insights occurred? This is an entry into rethinking, changing practice and what we do with our students.

PDE3's Guide for Meaningful Reflections - READ THIS CAREFULLY!

This document provides three features of meaningful reflections to incorporate into your writing. Below each description, you will find that the essential feature is absent within the example on the left and present in the example on the right. Each of these examples are written from the perspective of a teacher who completed a professional development course on 'Using action research to inform instruction.'

Strive to meet each of these features throughout your portfolio reflections. Any reflections like the examples in the left columns will **NOT** be acceptable.

1) Moving from description to examination of your learning

Often it is necessary to describe elements of what happened during the professional development experience, but sometimes there is too much emphasis on what occurred rather than what was learned from the activity. Please remember to move beyond a description of activities.

Describing what occurred	✓Examining what you learned
“...In the first session, the instructor provided an overview of the action research cycle. The cycle consists of four phases – Plan, Act, Observe, and Reflect. We then had the opportunity to identify a problem we would want to address in our own classroom and consider possible instructional interventions (Plan), select an intervention that aligns to the problem (Act), think of data collection strategies (Observe), and how we might analyze the data to understand if the intervention was successful (Reflect)...”	“...While thinking through each step of the action research cycle with a hypothetical problem, I realized that the cycle is not perfectly linear during implementation. The cycle serves as a useful guide, but a teacher needs to be flexible enough to move back and forth from one stage to another. In my hypothetical example, a teacher would collect data by examining student portfolios during a project-based learning unit. However, the data could be collected and examined at different times in the middle of the unit, and then be used to inform instructional decisions along the way. The teacher would be asked to move back and forth between phases, just as I would want my students to move back and forth between data collection and data analysis phases of a scientific investigation...”

2) Backing up general claims with examples:

Throughout reflections, claims are made. Whether you are making a claim about how two concepts connect together or an idea you've constructed from course activities, claims are strengthened when you provide a specific example or line of reasoning to support them.

General claim	✓ Claim supported with examples
"...Action research is useful to teachers because it can be used to support the implementation of student-centered instruction..."	"...Action research is useful to teachers because it can support the implementation of student-centered instruction. For example, if a teacher collected data while completing a PBL project, they might learn that students needed more scaffolding. While students are often engaged with constructivist learning approaches, they sometimes feel uncertain about how to move forward with a project. Teachers need some form of data, whether formal or informal, to inform them of students' challenges during open-ended learning experiences. This knowledge of challenges can then inform instructional scaffolds..."

3) Translating new knowledge to future practice / student learning

The majority of professional development workshops occur outside of the classroom, and therefore it becomes easy to concentrate on new knowledge you gained from the workshop. However, it's imperative to explicitly discuss how that new knowledge translates to your instructional practice, and ultimately how your instructional practice will support student learning.

Isolated from instruction/learning	✓ Connected to instruction/learning
"...The data collection strategies helped me understand that research is a part of the teaching process. Previously, I had always considered 'research' to be for people in academic realms, and not for practitioners. Now I understand that there are practical approaches to research specifically designed for teachers to better understand their students..."	"...I learned that research-based approaches to constructing survey items can have an impact on the information I gather from students, which in turn affects my ability to respond to data and improve my instruction. For example, with my first survey construction attempt, I learned the importance of avoiding 'double-barreled items.' If I list more than one concept in the following item – "I spend 5-7 hours a week on this class's self-paced quizzes and online simulations outside of normal school hours" – I will not understand if students are spending most of that time on the quizzes or the simulations. To improve the 'help session' portion of my classroom instruction, I need to know the specific online activities that students find most useful outside of school hours. I cannot differentiate instruction to meet students' needs without specific data, and..."

Each participant's LRP may contain a variety of evidence, but each artifact MUST have a caption. A caption is a statement of what the document is and its application of learning.

Below is an example of a Caption

Pre-Course Survey Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

The pre-course survey was given to us before we began the course so we could think about where we currently are. This will be used to compare the post-course survey so it can show our growth. This will show evidence of learning through the "What is one goal you would like to set for yourself..." question. I feel that multiple choice questions don't always provide a glimpse into the learning that occurred, but the written section can because teachers will be able to elaborate their learning and the journey they went through during this course.

Pre-Course Survey

Pre-Course Survey Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

The pre-course survey is meant to get me thinking and reflecting about my current understanding of the course's content. Below are my answers to a few questions that relate to the neuroscience of learning. They represent my knowledge before consuming the course materials and thus can serve as a benchmark for writing future reflections.

1. What is your current level of understanding of the neuroscience behind effective instruction?

I understand that the mental processes that help make a student successful or unsuccessful—working memory and motivation for example—are mediated by chemical resources and neural processes in the brain. These processes are shaped by all the forces which influence development: habits, upbringing, nutrition, genetics, culture, and personality/temperament. Based on a short dive into the topic of mental fatigue recently, I learned that there are multiple competing theories which try to explain the mechanisms of mental fatigue, which of course plays a role in effective instruction. Resource depletion theory says that it is the overuse of resources such as dopamine in the brain that creates the conditions of fatigue. Ego depletion theory simply states that willpower (ego) is its own resource that is finite.

Apart from motivation as a variable, I also understand that there are specific neural mechanisms responsible for the process of integrating knowledge, changing beliefs, or learning procedures. Myelination is the primary mechanism in adult learning while pruning is the primary mechanism in childhood. In adolescence, both are relevant to the learning process.

In general, a cognitive approach to understanding the mind as a composition of discrete computational processes helps drive research in neuroscience, and vice versa. This is the basis for Cognitive Neuroscience being considered its own field of research. In the classroom, for me personally, I most heavily rely on cognitive science's idea of working memory to drive my instructional practices. For example, I have to limit the number of steps required to complete tasks at any given time when I am asking students to take in new information, or to practice a new procedure. I rely on neuroscience when I direct students to take short breaks every 15 to 25 minutes during extended periods of focus time in order to help their dopamine replenish. What is meant by the "replenishment" of dopamine as a mechanism in the brain is where my understanding ends.

2. What do you currently do in your classroom to establish a **Friendly and Welcoming Environment** where students experience **Choice, Social Support, and Differentiation**?

I welcome students at the door when they first enter the classroom, handing them a playing card that will determine their seat for the day. The randomization of seats, I have found, separates groups of students whose group behaviors are harmful to classroom learning while also putting people together who

otherwise would not have worked together. As a result, I have seen new friendships form and trust increase because of randomized seating.

I allow student choice by writing the tasks for each class period on the whiteboard at the start of class and allowing students to complete those tasks in any order they choose.

Students also have choice in who they work with on projects, which books to read, and what topics to research or write about for papers and presentations. This creates natural levels of differentiation insofar as students select books and topics that are within their ability and interests.

During “independent work” times, which generally takes up 25-40 minutes of class time each day, students receive differentiated instruction through one on one meetings with the teachers who are present in the classroom that day (there is a rotating cast of TA’s at my school). This is where students show their work, ask for guidance, and receive grades and/or general feedback.

Social support happens naturally through group work or actively through “whiteboarding” tasks in which teacher-determined small groups answer basic prompts or make grammatical corrections on whiteboards and windows around the classroom. During practice sessions for performance-based tasks such as dramatic monologues, students present their work and share positive and constructive feedback on their writing and speaking with their peers.

3. What is one goal you would like to set for yourself to achieve and reflect upon? Why are you choosing this goal?

I want to use what I learn in this course to create a “good school habits” mini-lecture series to deliver to my class throughout the coming school year. I want to do this because in my first year and a half of teaching, I found that my instruction was lacking in direct modeling or advice about the implicit hard skills of being a student, such as keeping an organized backpack, being proactive about getting help from teachers, keeping digital files organized, and avoiding mental fatigue and burnout by self-regulating emotions and attention.

Habit #1: Ready to Learn

Reflection Log

Note: This caption applies to all reflections in the course, including Modules 6-8)

Reflection Log Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

This reflection log is a collection of course questions that correspond to each module and my responses to them. These questions are reflective in nature and represent my metacognitive process while learning the course material.

Module 1: Introduction

1. What information or concepts from this module most resonated with you? Why?

The video about the infographic of Kobe Bryant's career baskets reminded me that data visualization can be beautiful, and that success is a process that necessarily involves "failure" (Bryant, perhaps among the top 5 great NBA players of all time, only made 55% of his shots). I personally have an appreciation for this fact, especially as a musician and programmer, where 99% of my time is spent fiddling with new ideas in an attempt to discover what works. I love practicing these things because through them, I can experience an incredible amount of learning in a 10 minute period. In light of my success rate in my hobbies, Kobe's record of 55% seems incredibly high! I think this number illustrates the risk-taking, explorative nature of effective performance.

I learned in my last two years of teaching that my students do not approach my material the same way I approach my own learning. I have known this fact for a long time and continually go to great lengths to try to express my personal approach to learning through my pedagogy. However, being new to the profession, I am still spending much of my time learning the basics of quantifying students' attainment of concepts, which is an important part of my job, rather than trying to make a learning experience for students that is deeply experimental, accepting of failure, and enriching to natural curiosity. The difference between how I learn and how I teach has been my greatest source of frustration and motivation to improve in my pedagogy. It is the reason I am taking this course! To be honest, I am not sure yet how I can apply the insight of this video—that learning and performance are explorative, risky tasks—to my classroom; discovering how is a central purpose of my participation at this time.

2. What did you learn about that you can apply to your own instructional practices?

The module's mention of creating an emotionally safe learning environment resonated with me as a great need in my own classroom. I have everything I "need" in my classroom, but an air of chaos sometimes lingers due to my frequent improvisation of lessons. Many students have become daily passive learners in my classroom because they don't always know what to expect. Further, it is the students who need the most support (for their own various reasons) who are most likely to be confused by a change in plans. This coming school year, I am excited to be getting a pre-made curriculum to deliver to my students. This will help myself and my students greatly as I will be able to spend my time preparing for classroom facilitation rather than content creation.

Module 2: Habit #1-READY to LEARN- Amygdala Management

1. What information or concepts from this module most resonated with you? Why?

As it was pointed out to me in a previous professional development task, it is very important to view learner differences as assets rather than deficits. The module's reminder to create a safe and welcoming environment in the classroom is valuable for me because I can forget that my negative thoughts about students can be portrayed in ways that harm my students' learning but are otherwise invisible to me. My modeling the belief that differences are a source of strength will be important for developing a welcoming culture in my classroom next school year.

2. What did you learn about that you can apply to your own instructional practices?

I can place a greater emphasis on developing this supportive and positive environment in my classroom next year. I can do this through preparing students to work together on group projects, allowing them to choose their topics and partners, and creating rituals and routines that engage students' collaborative problem solving skills each day. This way, students absorb knowledge through shared language and reduce amygdala response through positive peer interactions.

Module 3- STAR LEARNING WALKS: Learn to Observe

1. What information or concepts from this module most resonated with you? Why?

The "big idea" of this module that a common language is necessary resonated with me the most. This is something I highly value in my most intellectually stimulating relationships. Even though the module did not explicitly connect the relationship between strong peer bonds and shared language, those two things are very clearly connected in my own experience. I recently had many of my long-time friends come visit me in Hawaii—many of whom had never met each other before. They quickly developed a strong group bond, and we had a wonderful week together. However, I was surprised to find that these same people did not connect with the friends I had met in the past six years while living on island—there was a clear sense of group fractioning that occurred, though there were no bad interactions. I realized that the difference was in their shared language; the group of strangers who all became fast friends were all artists in some regard. Even though they had very different professions and personalities, they all shared a "meta" language about how they fit into their cultures, because as artists, that is what they're thinking about all the time!

2. What did you learn about that you can apply to your own instructional practices?

After making this connection, I am having so many flashbacks about times when I thought my own classroom looked and felt like a "tight ship" and when it felt like everyone (including myself) was slogging through mud. The times when I made the learning objectives very clear and established a daily routine of discussing the new academic vocabulary were the times that felt like my strongest instruction. I appreciated how the teacher in the video used many visual "checkpoints" that students could focus their attention on, even as she lectured. The posters that summarized the goals of the day created a clear learning environment and established a shared language. I will rely on posters, writing out the learning objectives, and discussing with academic language more in this school year.

Module 4- STAR LEARNING WALKS: Learn to Reflect

1. What information or concepts from this module most resonated with you? Why?

Using the rubric to form my observations reminded me of a concept from another teacher of mine who says that having a clear aim shapes the things that you perceive. The rubric is like a lens to see effective instruction through. I think this resonated with me because it was a clear example of setting quality aims and letting those aims increase my “field of vision” with regard to the instructional video.

2. What did you learn about that you can apply to your own instructional practices?

The most clear personal reflection I had was actually about the time period of the video. It seemed that the video was from before 2014 –long enough ago that the culture of today’s high school students is clearly different than that depicted in the video, but not so long ago that the instructional methods are very different from my own. I heard a teacher talking today about how many universities are “in the dark ages” of technologically-driven education, relying heavily on a simple film setup in traditional university lecture halls. However, with the technology available for easy video editing and rendering of relevant graphics, it doesn’t make sense NOT to advance the methods of lecturing and expand them out to wider audiences. I think I want to continue to question my own reliance on the technology that I received instruction through while I was a high school student and consider meeting my students at a more culturally familiar mode whenever I can. For example, last year I experimented with editing and producing a video of myself completing one of the packet homework assignments for my ELA class. Students paid attention with an extremely different level of focus—so much, in fact, that the video received an applause at the end, despite being about what was possibly the most boring thing to them (taking repeating notes on long reading assignments). I am excited to make more demo videos as I begin to roll out my new curriculum for 7th and 8th grade ELA this year.

Module 5-STAR LEARNING WALKS: Learn to Commit

1. What information or concepts from this module most resonated with you? Why?

That focus plays a central role in developing new habits. First, one must focus on the specific behaviors and habits they want to change. Then, one must choose the behaviors they want to replace old habits with. Habits do not easily change if the teacher is focused on changing too many behaviors at the same time. This methodical approach is exactly the kind of approach that creates change in people’s lives, and teaching is one such category. This resonated with me because, for one, my last year of teaching was very difficult, and the concept of committing to change in only one or two domains at a time really helped resolve my confusion about what went wrong in my instruction; I was focused on solving everything that arose every day, but lacked a methodical approach to transforming one element of my instruction at a time. It also resonated with me because the domains of my life outside of teaching, namely fitness, has benefited tremendously from a methodical commitment to improving in two or three skills at a time over the past two years. I have become a certified strength coach in the process and am even starting to offer services through my school to our student athletes who want to use strength to prevent injuries.

2. What did you learn about that you can apply to your own instructional practices?

I want to select just two domains of instruction to improve on for one month at a time as I start this school year, in keeping with this principle of commitment. In terms of the ready to learn rubric, I want to focus on creating a friendly and welcoming environment for my students by building rapport through more casual conversations while also continuing to support an emotionally safe environment by randomizing and facilitating student interaction between peers beyond their regular friend groups. For students, this is a “plus” and a “minus,” but the neuroscience shows that it is a plus-plus: students need to know that the daily expectation is to interact with all of their peers and to be focused on schoolwork, while also relying on their teacher to create an environment conducive to learning and supporting emotional safety. These are habits that easily erode when not focused and committed. I commit to focusing on these habits for the next month at least.

Module 6

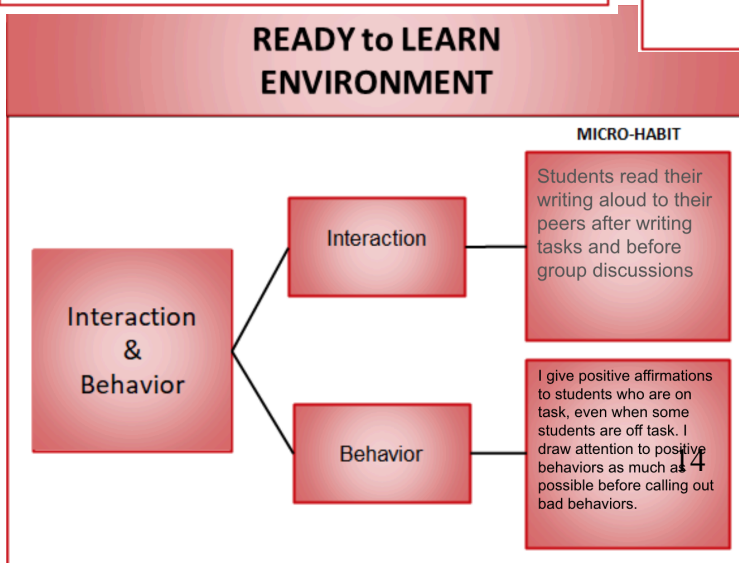
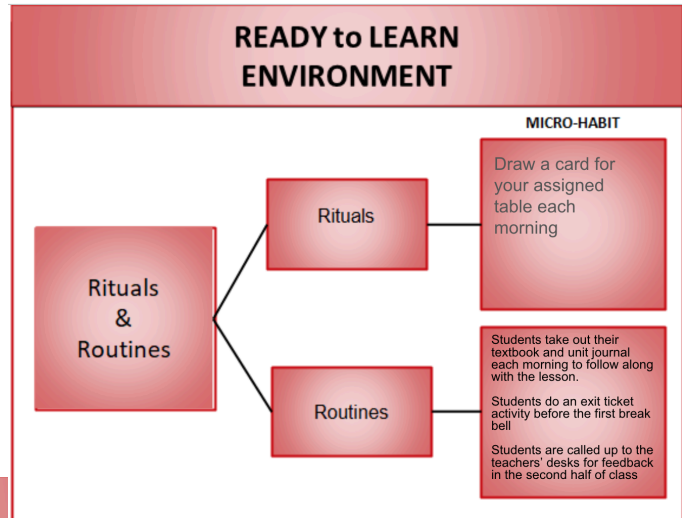
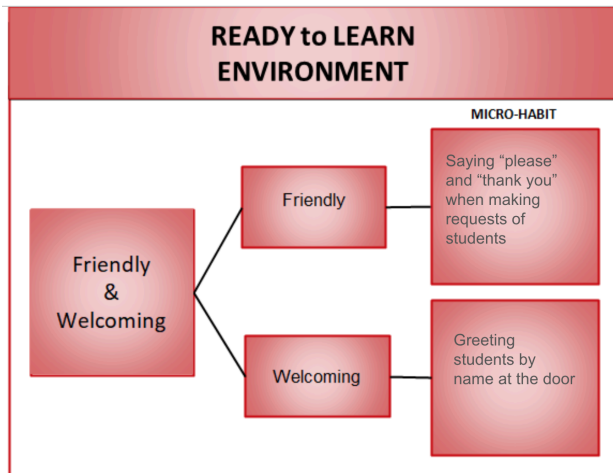
Habit Mapping: Environment

Module 6 Habit Mapping Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

These screenshots are habit maps that are meant to provide a clear guide for my focus behaviors in instruction. The three categories–Friendly and Welcoming, Rituals and Routines, and Interaction and Behavior–are all components of a “Ready to Learn” environment because they help reduce student cognitive load to better facilitate learning. Each micro-habit that I have listed on these habit maps contribute to a ready to learn environment by increasing students’ sense of emotional safety, accountability, and predictability.

[Please copy and paste your completed habit maps from your Google Slides assignment into this portfolio]



Module 6 Pedagogical Lesson Plan

Module 6 Pedagogical Lesson Plan Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

Pedagogical Habit Mapping Lesson Planning Template *READY to LEARN*

Habit Indicator	What can the teacher say and/or do?	What can the teacher have students say and/or do?	What are some types of student evidence I could collect
Environment	Friendly & Welcoming - Welcome students as they enter the room - Say please and thank you when asking students to do things	Friendly & Welcoming - Greet each other as they find their seats - Say please and thank you to each other - Give positive feedback and compliment each others' work during feedback	Friendly & Welcoming Written student feedback on peer-assessed assignments
	Rituals & Routines - Create a routine for entering and leaving the classroom - Establish patterns in the daily workflow of instruction	Rituals & Routines - Come prepared with writing tools, backpack and water bottle. - Use the restroom during breaks - Start each class by doing a ritual warm-up activity	Rituals & Routines Screenshot of digital work log for morning start activity
	Positive Student Interactions - Model positive interactions with students through the friendly and welcoming habits - Facilitate social/emotional learning activities	Positive Student Interactions - Be open and willing to participate with their partner of the day - Admit to one's own mistakes and ask for forgiveness from anyone they may have impacted	Positive Student Interactions - Keep a list of positive moments of student interactions in my daily teaching journal - A class contract signed by the students

Module 6 Lesson Narrative

Please choose a lesson to use for Module 6. This may be a lesson you have taught in the past, or one that is new to you. You will be applying the concepts learned throughout the module. Provide a narrative that describes your lesson from beginning to end. This does not need to be a formal lesson plan, and no standards are required. This narrative should provide a clear and thorough description of the lesson to give context for the habit maps, pedagogical lesson planners, and student evidence for Module 6. Be sure to incorporate ideas from your pedagogical habit map and lesson planner.

Module 6 Lesson Narrative Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

This is a lesson plan from a lesson that I delivered to my 7th graders this week. The purpose of this lesson plan is to highlight the habit mapping components emphasized by Module 6. The lesson plan incorporates ideas from my own habit map including greeting students at the door, modeling positive feedback, and facilitating positive peer interactions. Writing this document helped me reflect on the habits that I already have in place but want to focus on solidifying in the future. It also helped me rehearse the meaning of specific target instructional competencies of the Ready To Learn habit.

7th Grade ELA

Unit 1, Sub-Unit 1, Lesson 2

The lesson begins with me greeting each student at the door, handing them a playing card that shows their table assignment for the day. I greet them by name with a smile, ensuring they feel welcomed. The playing cards provide quick, organized seating and promote a neutral social environment, which supports emotional safety and predictability.

Once inside, students place their things down and take out their textbooks and unit journals. I review the previous lesson by reading an anonymous student writing sample from the previous lesson aloud. Students then discuss at their tables the details that made that writing sample stand out. This discussion helps them identify strong writing techniques while promoting positive peer feedback.

Next, we focus on new content, highlighting three types of details in narrative writing: dialogue, action, and sensory details. I ask students to read over their own writing from the previous class, then randomly call on them to explain the details they included. This routine helps reinforce the importance of these techniques.

Students then work silently for 15 minutes on a new writing prompt, using all three types of details. The timer is set, and a slide is displayed with clear writing rules: no talking, no distractions, and use the full time for writing.

When the timer ends, students clean up and head to break. After returning, they complete a journal task while watching a documentary. During this time, the TA and I call students up individually to review their writing and provide personalized guidance. This one-on-one time allows us to offer tailored support, reinforcing a supportive environment and helping them improve for future tasks.

Module 6 Student Evidence

Module 6 Student Evidence Caption:

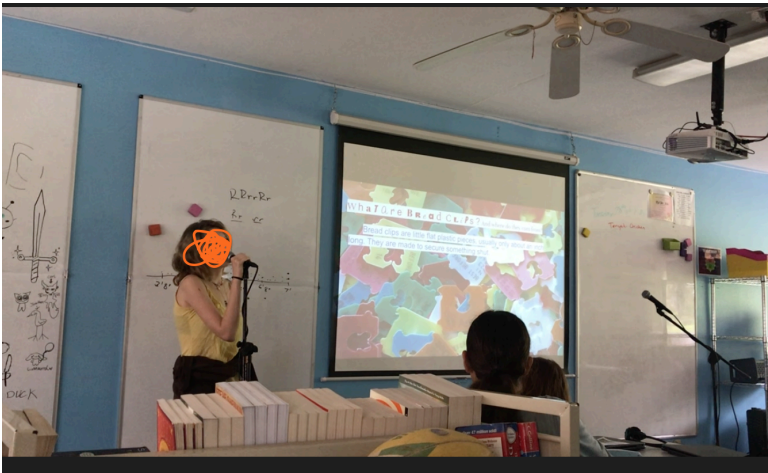
What is this document and its application of learning?

Module 6: Student Evidence

You can include student evidence by cutting and pasting an image or text evidence, or by embedding a link to a video or image in your Google Drive.

NOTE: This sample is not from the lesson described above. I was not able to get clearance to film the lesson described above in time to complete this portfolio. Images of past students are shown below.

Student Sample # 1



Provide evidence of students experiencing a **Friendly & Welcoming Environment** (this can be in the form of an image or video)

→ This is a screenshot of a video of a student presentation during our ELA “awesome fest,” a culmination of the journaling tasks described above that students complete near the end of this lesson series. Students are to go through the notes they took throughout the year and demonstrate their learning through a presentation on any topic that caught their interest along the way. This particular student gave a humorous and informative presentation on the importance of

bread clips.

Explain what you did intentionally to create a **Friendly & Welcoming** environment during this lesson.

→ I made it clear to students that all interests are welcome to be presented as long as they were school appropriate, developed out of a genuine participation with our learning objectives, and followed my guidelines for presentations. This allowed students to express themselves in front of their classmates while also having more time to enrich their own pursuit of curiosity.

How could indicators of a **Friendly & Welcoming Environment** show up more in your classroom?

→ I think students could be given more opportunities to provide each other positive feedback. I don’t spend as much time as I would like giving students instruction on how to give and receive feedback, and in the past, I have found those lessons to generate positive feelings about school and each other among students.

How does this student evidence explicitly connect to what you learned in this module and how you are changing your practice based on the research?

→ This student evidence shows my understanding of the principle of a friendly and supportive environment in the classroom. I genuinely want to know what students are interested in, and I express that interest by spending a significant amount of class time on allowing students to share these presentations.

Student Sample # 2



Provide evidence of students experiencing **Rituals & Routines** (this can be in the form of an image or video)

→ This is an image of my 8th grade ELA class during our morning routine. This routine precedes the above described lesson plan. I have students practice their “membean” (personalized vocabulary tool) for 15 minutes while I take attendance and count lunch orders. This ritual gives students time to work quietly and independently as some students arrive tardy. It allows me as the teacher to have a period of non-direct instruction so that I can square away the most crucial logistics of the day.

In this instance, I also had the Olympic gold medal basketball game playing in the background quietly. After establishing this vocabulary practice routine, I experimented that playing something on the TV in the background settled side conversations while helping other students to focus on their work better—a fact that I did not discover for a long time due to my skepticism that it would work. My neighboring teacher follows a similar routine and seemed to have positive results, so I began trying it out.

Explain what you did intentionally to ensure students were engaged in **Rituals & Routines**.

I explained to students as they waited for their seating assignment cards at the classroom door that my expectation was for them to “do 15 minutes of membean” to start the class day. I start each class day like this with my 8th graders so they know what to expect when they first arrive in the classroom. It sets a tone for self-directed learning, takes the pressure off while also giving students the freedom to work at their own pace.

How could **Rituals & Routines** show up more in your classroom?

→ I don’t yet have a solid end-of-class routine. I could establish more regular exit ticket activities after I do student feedback sessions. This would create a sense of routine at the end of the class period to decrease cognitive load and to increase retention of information.

How does this student evidence explicitly connect to what you learned in this module and how you are changing your practice based on the research?

→ This routine establishes an easy, effective, and predictable pattern for students to start their day with. Doing daily vocabulary practice maximizes cognitive effort for learning and rehearsing new information while also providing me time to complete necessary teaching tasks behind the scenes.

Student Sample # 3

Provide evidence of students experiencing **Positive Interactions**. (this can be in the form of an image or video)



Explain what you did intentionally to ensure students engaged in **Positive Interactions** during this lesson.

→ This activity was based on a professional development activity put on by our school art teacher in which staff participated in a creative game called “TASK.” The objective is to draw a pre-written task from a bin, complete that task, and then create a new task for another person to complete. The goal is to foster open-ended thinking and reduce the fear of failure within the learning environment, a necessary quality of a true thinking classroom. I replicated this activity for students using the boxes left over from a shipment of new textbooks that arrived the previous day. Students’

tasks asked them to work together to solve simple problems with no specific solution (such as “make a flying machine”). Students can be seen in this photo working together to complete a variety of tasks drawn from a task bin. This was a great way to get students mixing in together during the first week of school and lowers the level of intensity of engaging with a new peer through parallel play.

This particular photo is from a slightly different lesson than the one described in full above because it was taken on a different class day. Instead of the step describing reading an anonymous piece of writing aloud, students on this class day first participated in the creative tasks (all of which added up to “building a city” in the classroom) and then completed their daily writing task on the prompt “Write a story about something you built in the city.” From one student’s journal: “My favorite part of the city is the towering skyscraper I built, it stands tall with three boxes stacked on top of each other, taped together securely, and I added so many paper windows all around it so it would look like a real office building and from the ground. It looks huge almost like it’s touching the clouds.” We have a long way to go with regard to defining what makes a story and how to edit grammatical structure, but this was a strong start to a year in which we will rely heavily on the imagination for motivated writing sessions.

How could **Positive Student Interactions** show up more in your classroom?

→ In my daily textbook-driven lessons, I ask students to share with their table mates their thoughts on a specific prompt. I would like to regularly introduce more open-ended tasks to students so that they can experience playfulness and creativity more often. This would balance out the amount of pressure I put on them to “be right” during our hour-long lessons. An example of this might be to ask students to create a skit representing a certain scene from our readings.

How does this student evidence explicitly connect to what you learned in this module and how you are changing your practice based on the research?

→ The TASK game gets students working together to solve problems on the basis of nothing but their own thinking. This allowed students to express their thoughts and ideas with each other more openly and without performance pressure, which is high among my middle schoolers due to large gaps in learning and cognitive performance. I would thus categorize the benefits of this activity as an Amygdala Deactivation Activity.

Module 6 Reflection

1. How might you change your classroom instruction, engage with students for their learning, and/or assess students differently based on the learning from your Module 6 student evidence?

→ My emphasis on strong daily routines and peer interactions have paid off in the past school year. I have a long way to go with regard to perfecting these systems. In the future, I will increase the amount of times spent facilitating small group discussions after our morning independent work routine. A tendency (though not a necessity) in the pursuit of efficient instruction is to isolate students from one another—when using responsive learning software, for example, students work on their own at a computer. My new textbook has group discussions written into the curriculum, though it does not explicitly state how to implement such discussions. One way to optimize for quality group discussions would be to implement fishbowl discussions throughout each unit. This is a method that decreases the pressure on any single speaker (such as with powerpoint presentations) while also holding all students accountable to sharing some idea with their peers.

2. Did you make any modifications to your initial lesson idea and/or would you make any changes to this lesson in the future? If so, what changes did/would you make and why?

→ I did not make any modifications to my lesson plans for the photographed activities. I also did not make any modifications for the above described lesson plan's writing activities.

3. Describe the overall student learning and engagement with this lesson.

→ With regard to the lesson I wrote about above, students were surprisingly engaged. Engagement increased when I read aloud and showed a sample of student work. It was as if students knew they were all liable to have their work read aloud. They were able to acknowledge and provide positive feedback to a peer who did not know her work would be the one chosen as an example.

4. What strategies related to **ENVIRONMENT** did you implement? How did it impact the lesson overall? What would you do differently next time to positively impact the learning **ENVIRONMENT**?

→ Using the seating assignment strategy (handing out playing cards that represent certain tables in the room) was the foremost environmental strategy for creating predictability and controlling behavior in the classroom. Seating assignments improved the quality of students' focus and participation by ensuring that students did not cluster unevenly into their own friend groups. It reduced the tension between myself and students who may have otherwise been spending a lot of time chatting rather than writing.

Next time, I may also implement a fishbowl discussion, setting seats into two concentric circles and having students rotate in and out of discussion. This would be a dramatic change to the classroom environment, but is one which does not have to occur every day—perhaps once per month at most as students must spend time preparing for these discussions.

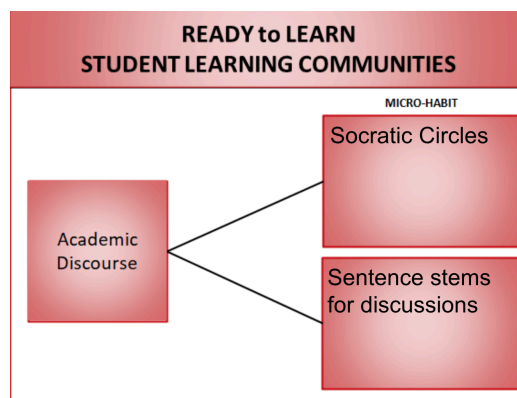
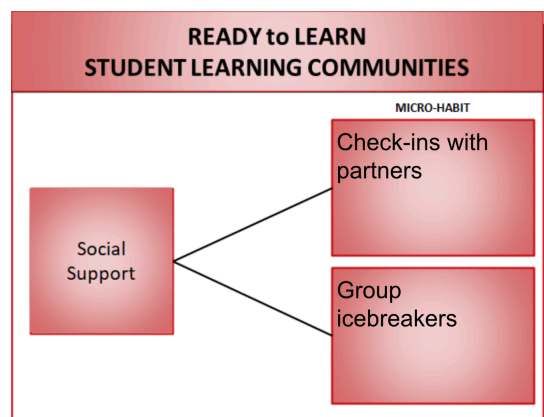
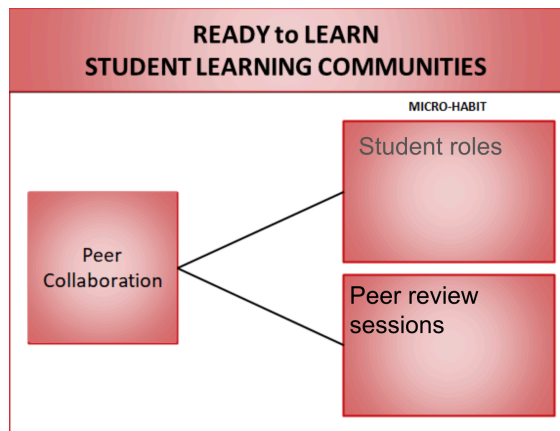
Module 7

Habit Mapping: Student Learning Communities

Module 7 Habit Mapping Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

[Please copy and paste your completed habit maps from your Google Slides assignment into this portfolio]



Module 7 Pedagogical Lesson Plan

Module 7 Pedagogical Lesson Plan Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

Pedagogical Habit Mapping Lesson Planning Template *READY to LEARN*

Habit Indicator	What can the teacher say and/or do?	What can the teacher have students say and/or do?	What are some types of student evidence I could collect
Student Learning Communities	Process Procedures with Peers -Assign group facilitator roles -Provide clear instructions for group work tasks	Process Procedures with Peers -Work together to solve a problem or complete a project -Engage in peer review sessions, providing feedback to one another.	Process Procedures with Peers -Group project outcomes -Peer feedback forms -Recordings of group interactions
	Collaborate with Peers for Social Support -Encourage check-ins between partners during tasks. -Arrange icebreaker activities to build trust and teamwork.	Collaborate with Peers for Social Support -Help a partner find the correct page in resources -Offer assistance to classmates during lessons	Collaborate with Peers for Social Support -Observation notes of peer support -Informal assessments of partner check-ins
	Academic Discourse -Model the use of sentence stems for academic conversations -Conduct a Socratic seminar to promote critical discussion.	Academic Discourse -Use sentence stems in discussions ("I agree with ____ because ____") -Participate in Socratic seminars, using evidence when debating.	Academic Discourse -Transcripts of class discussions -Student self-reflections on academic dialogue

Module 7 Lesson Narrative

Please choose a lesson to use for Module 7. This may be a lesson you have taught in the past, or one that is new to you. You will be applying the concepts learned throughout the module. Provide a narrative that describes your lesson from beginning to end. This does not need to be a formal lesson plan, and no standards are required. This narrative should provide a clear and thorough description of the lesson to give context for the habit maps, pedagogical lesson planners, and student evidence for Module 7.

Module 7 Lesson Narrative Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

This is an overview of a lesson I have led in the past for my ELA classes. This narrative lesson plan forms the backbone of a classic group discussion style lesson that I lead often throughout my school years. It will serve as a sample of my instruction to analyze against the three habits of Peer Collaboration, Social Support, and Academic Discourse in my instruction.

Students enter the classroom as I greet them by their name and hand them a playing card to indicate their seat for the day. Once students are seated, I ask them to take out their journals and write about a time when they felt unsure about what the “right thing to do” was.

After 5 minutes of writing, I ask students to take turns sharing what they wrote about in their table groups. I allow a few minutes for discussion and then ask students to share their thoughts aloud.

I then introduce the Trolley problem, a philosophical thought experiment that asks students to decide if it is right to knowingly end one person’s life in order to save the lives of multiple others. After showing a short video that explains the Trolley problem, I ask students to discuss it with their table mates.

After some time to discuss, I begin collecting student thoughts on the whiteboard. I create separate columns for utilitarian and deontological types of responses. Class dismisses for break around this time.

When class returns, I have students prepare for a Socratic fishbowl discussion. I call students at random to the center of the fishbowl, about 6 students at a time. I explain the expectations for sharing in the discussion. Then I proceed to ask the inner circle about an ethical problem and debate about the morally right and wrong choices within that situation. After about 5 minutes, I have the groups rotate. It takes about 3-4 cycles to get through the whole class.

I apply this format of lesson plan to many topics throughout the year; the Trolley Problem is one of many of my lessons that follow this format.

Module 7 Student Evidence

Module 7 Student Evidence Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

This section shows evidence of how I implemented strategies to build the community quality of students' experience. I highlight specific examples of peer collaboration, social support, and academic discourse, showing how these approaches positively impacted student engagement and connection.

Module 7: Student Evidence

You can include student evidence by cutting and pasting an image or text evidence, or by embedding a link to a video or image in your Google Drive.

Student Sample # 1

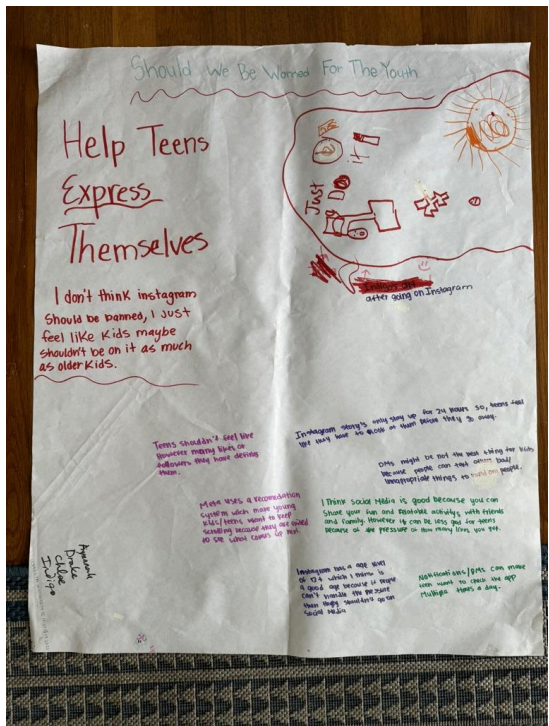
Provide evidence of students **Processing Procedures with Peers**. (this can be in the form of an image or video)

→ This is a poster made by students in a lesson of a similar style as the one described above (facilitated discussion, watch/read new information, group discussion activity). The task was to create and present an informational poster that summarizes the main points of an article about social media lawsuits.

Explain what you did intentionally to provide opportunities for students to **Process Procedures with Peers** during this lesson.

→ In this task, I handed out instructions for creating an informational poster about an article that students read in class. I told students that I would explain the task verbally only once, then hand out the guidelines. Students then were to decide who would be responsible for collecting important facts from the article, who would be responsible for writing down those facts, and then who would design and write on the poster itself.

How could indicators of students **Processing Procedures with Peers** show up more in your classroom?

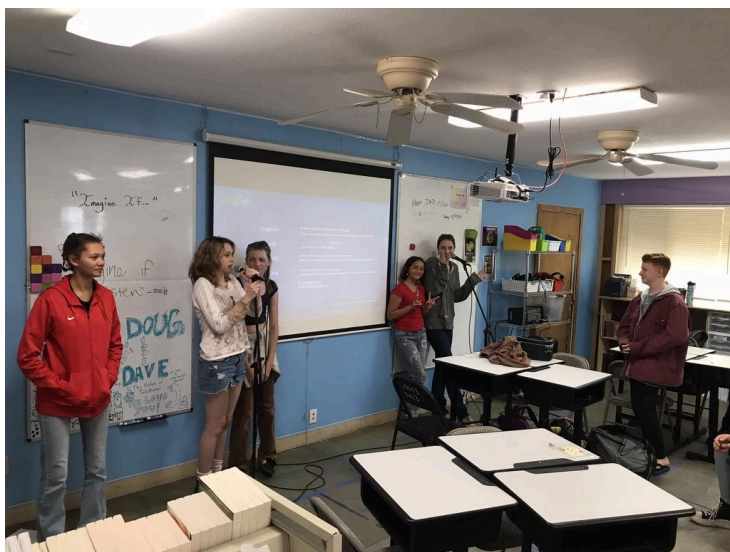


→ I can ask students to review and write on each other's writing assignments. I could also take notes about how students provide each other with feedback on days that we share our writing. In Socratic discussions, I can take notes on what each student says, particularly in how they reflect and respond to other students' ideas.

How does this student evidence explicitly connect to what you learned in this module and how you are changing your practice based on the research?

→ This is a fitting example of students having all the information they need to accomplish something, but then being given the space to communicate with each other about how exactly to get it done. Students **MUST** decide together about how to get something done when there is not a pre-defined pathway to get there.

Student Sample # 2



Provide evidence of students **Collaborating with Peers for Social Support**. this can be in the form of an image or video)

Explain what you did intentionally to ensure students Collaborated with Peers for Social Support during this lesson.

→ This photo shows students warming up for their group discussions during a break. This lesson followed the same format as the Trolley Problem discussion but on a social/emotional learning topic instead. I gave students the opportunity to practice speaking in the empty classroom with the new microphone/stage setup that we had (rearranging desks became cumbersome between standardized

testing dates).

How could **Collaboration for Social Support** show up more in your classroom?

→ I have previously given little time to my assigning of roles to students (i.e. process procedures). This activity actually showed me the importance of assigning such roles for the benefit of social support. When students have a clear role, they more readily provide the specific kind of support assigned to them, because it decreases the number of choices and ambiguity they are faced with. I think that I can increase collaboration for social support be first trying to assign group roles more frequently. In one lesson discussed in Module 6 (the "TASK" lesson), I explicitly assigned some students to the role of "hype person," whose job it was to go around the room and provide words of encouragement to each other. To my surprise, students loved this role a lot! I can imagine they would be open to receiving roles in more academic capacities as well.

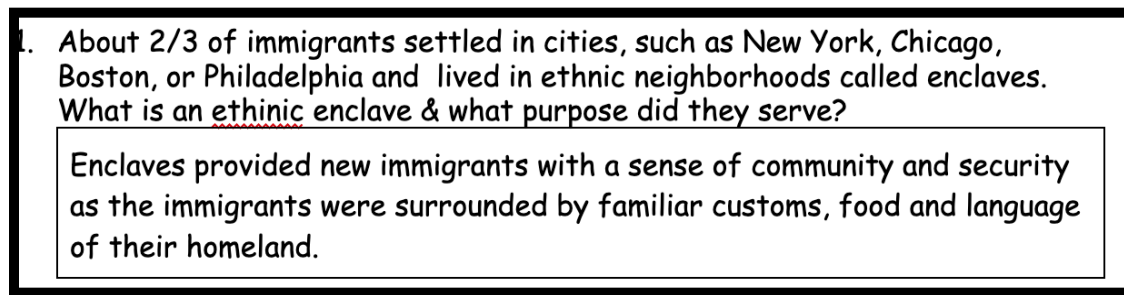
How does this student evidence explicitly connect to what you learned in this module and how you are changing your practice based on the research?

→ Fostering a classroom culture in which students feel comfortable giving and receiving feedback and assistance from each other sets a norm of connecting positively among peers. Moments of social connection are powerful adjudicators of one's sense of stress due to our sensitivity to social status. This is especially true among teens. When students have a greater sense of belonging through moments of connection, no matter how

small those moments are, it takes the load off of the amygdala to constantly sense danger in the face of uncertainty.

Student Sample # 3

Provide evidence of students engaging in **Academic Discourse**. (this can be in the form of an image or video)



1. About 2/3 of immigrants settled in cities, such as New York, Chicago, Boston, or Philadelphia and lived in ethnic neighborhoods called enclaves. What is an ethnic enclave & what purpose did they serve?

Enclaves provided new immigrants with a sense of community and security as the immigrants were surrounded by familiar customs, food and language of their homeland.

Explain what you did intentionally to ensure students engaged in **Academic Discourse** during this lesson.

→ This is a screenshot of a student assignment meant to prepare students for their participation in a Socratic fishbowl discussion. To prepare students to use the academic language of this lesson, students were presented with questions that asked them to define and use terminology related to the discussion prompt.

How could **Academic Discourse** show up more in your classroom?

→ I could print more posters of commonly used academic terms around the classroom. As I lecture or watch students work, sometimes I take for granted that they know common terms (such as parts of speech in grammar lessons) when in fact many do not know those words yet. I could do more activities in which students are required to use these terms, such as in games or facilitate discussions.

How does this student evidence explicitly connect to what you learned in this module and how you are changing your practice based on the research?

→ In preparation for the use of academic language in a socratic discussion, I prompted students with homework questions that would increase their retention of the language used in discussion questions. Students are then allowed to bring their printed assignments into discussion. This lowers the cognitive load of participating in a live discussion in two ways: 1) having answers already on-hand means students do not have to hold their future responses in working memory, freeing up working memory for paying attention to peers instead, and 2) it reduces the amount of time and energy needed to recall important terms that may arise in the discussion.

Module 7 Reflection

1. How might you change your classroom instruction, engage with students for their learning, and/or assess students differently based on the learning from your Module 7 student evidence?

I have experimented with many different ways of incorporating whole group discussions into our 80-minute period and have found that the longer students have to work collaboratively on preparation tasks (such as the posters or the homework assignments above), the better the outcomes in the actual discussion. However, no amount of preparation seems to help students with the nerves of being in front of the class. The image of the students practicing on the microphones was an exception—those students are involved in our school's Drama program, so their presence in classroom discussions is already strong. This is a signal to me that students in my age group may do better when the main focus of a lesson is on the small group portion rather than on a live demonstration of knowledge to the whole class.

2. Did you make any modifications to your initial lesson idea and/or would you make any changes to this lesson in the future? If so, what changes did/would you make and why?

In these lessons, I didn't initially consider splitting students into multiple groups for the fishbowl activity due to time constraints. Going forward, I would split students into smaller groups to allow for more frequent participation and rotation, reducing wait time and increasing each student's opportunity to contribute to the discussion.

3. Describe the overall student learning and engagement with this lesson.

The student engagement was generally high, especially during the Socratic discussion. The format of rotating groups for the fishbowl discussion maintained student interest as they eagerly anticipated their turn. The structured preparation the students had done in their homework seemed to pay off as well, as I explained in reflection question #1. I did not test students on knowledge that was discussed in groups—the group discussions themselves were my form of assessment for those lessons.

4. What strategies related to **STUDENT LEARNING COMMUNITIES** did you implement? How did it impact the lesson overall? What would you do differently next time to positively impact **STUDENT LEARNING COMMUNITIES**?

I implemented peer collaboration by assigning students to small groups for the fishbowl discussion, which encouraged interaction and built on their previous group discussions. I also fostered social support by assigning partners for preparation and ensuring that students checked in with one another. Next time, I would add more guided reflection post-discussion, encouraging students to evaluate both their contributions and how they supported their peers during the activity, fostering a deeper sense of personal responsibility and community.

Module 8

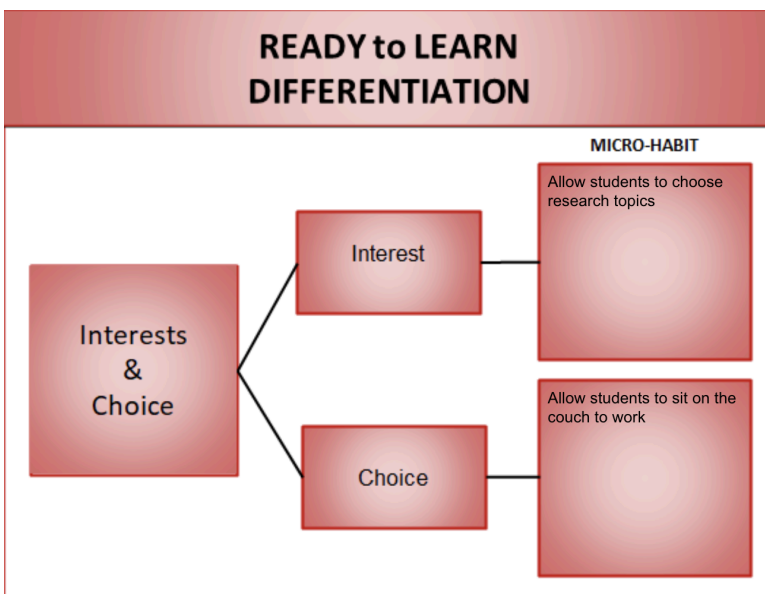
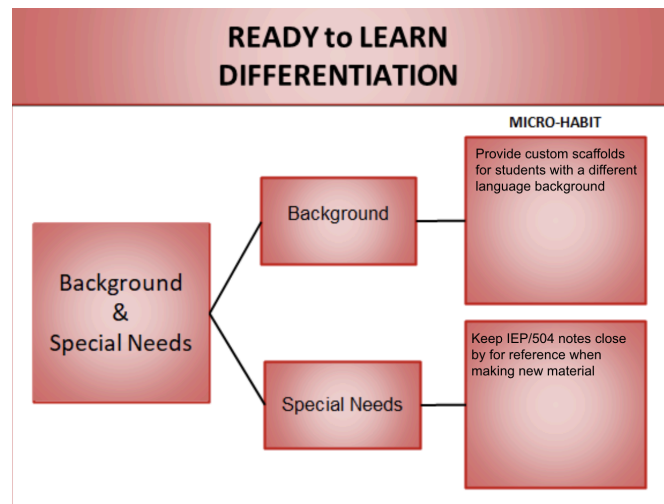
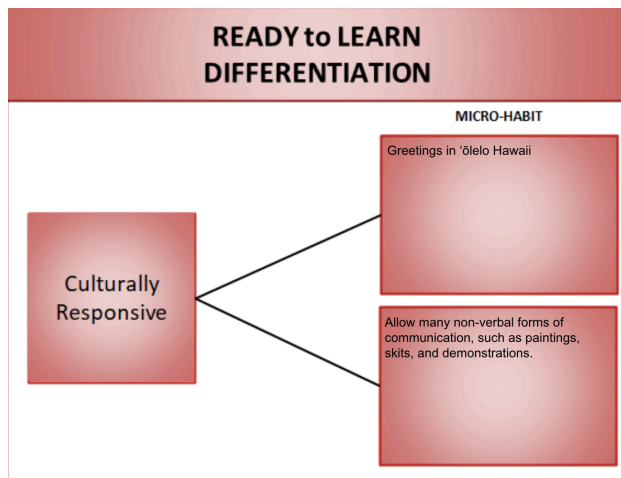
Habit Mapping: Differentiation and Choice

Module 8 Habit Mapping Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

These images show the micro-habits associated with supporting different dimensions of differentiation in the classroom. They are organized by type of differentiation—cultural, learning exceptionality, and personal interests—and represent multiple habits for establishing each of these awarenesses in the classroom.

[Please copy and paste your completed habit maps from your Google Slides assignment into this portfolio]



Module 8 Pedagogical Lesson Plan

Module 8 Pedagogical Lesson Plan Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

This table serves as a guide for implementing differentiated instruction within the classroom by focusing on key areas that differentiate students. The prompts within the table encourage instruction that considers many different student needs, and the responses represent different actionable approaches from teachers, students, and the products of the curriculum itself.

Pedagogical Habit Mapping Lesson Planning Template *READY to LEARN*

Habit Indicator	What can the teacher say and/or do?	What can the teacher have students say and/or do?	What are some types of student evidence I could collect
Differentiation	Race, Culture & Background -Incorporate Hawaiian cultural examples into lessons and materials	Race, Culture & Background -Share stories from their own cultural experiences -Discuss how their different perspectives relate to the content	Race, Culture & Background -Students' products that reflect their cultural heritage
	Special Needs, Interests & Goals -Adapt lessons to accommodate different styles and needs	Special Needs, Interests & Goals -Set personal learning goals -Choose topics or methods that reflect their needs and interests	Special Needs, Interests & Goals -Individualized learning plans based on IEP/504 documents -Products with student-selected topics

	Personal Choice -Provide options for how students demonstrate their learning (e.g. presentations, artwork, skits, music)	Personal Choice -Decide on the format of their projects -Choose which topics to explore based on their passion or curiosity	Personal Choice -A variety of project types submitted by students -Surveys or reflections on student engagement and choice
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Module 8 Lesson Narrative

Please choose a lesson to use for Module 8. This may be a lesson you have taught in the past, or one that is new to you. You will be applying the concepts learned throughout the module. Provide a narrative that describes your lesson from beginning to end. This does not need to be a formal lesson plan, and no standards are required. This narrative should provide a clear and thorough description of the lesson to give context for the habit maps, pedagogical lesson planners, and student evidence for Module 8.

Module 8 Lesson Narrative Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

This is a lesson narrative that outlines how I teach detailed narrative writing to my middle schoolers. It serves as a guide for understanding the context of the examples below, which themselves show how I incorporate the habits of differentiation in my lesson planning. In this lesson, I modify the writing task so that all learners are able to use it for their growth.

Students enter the classroom and are assigned seats by drawing a playing card. Because this lesson will include independent work, some students will be able to choose to sit on the classroom couch. I draw a random card from my set to determine the table group that gets to sit on the couch.

Once students are in their places, they are tasked with responding to a journal prompt from their textbook. The prompt varies between grades, but its goal is to add details and episodic focus to a memory. Students are asked to “zoom in” on a journal entry that they had previously completed and generate ideas to add detail. Finally, they write a new draft with that detail in it.

When students are finished with this, they move into independent work. That means they have a choice of completing any incomplete work from our class packets.

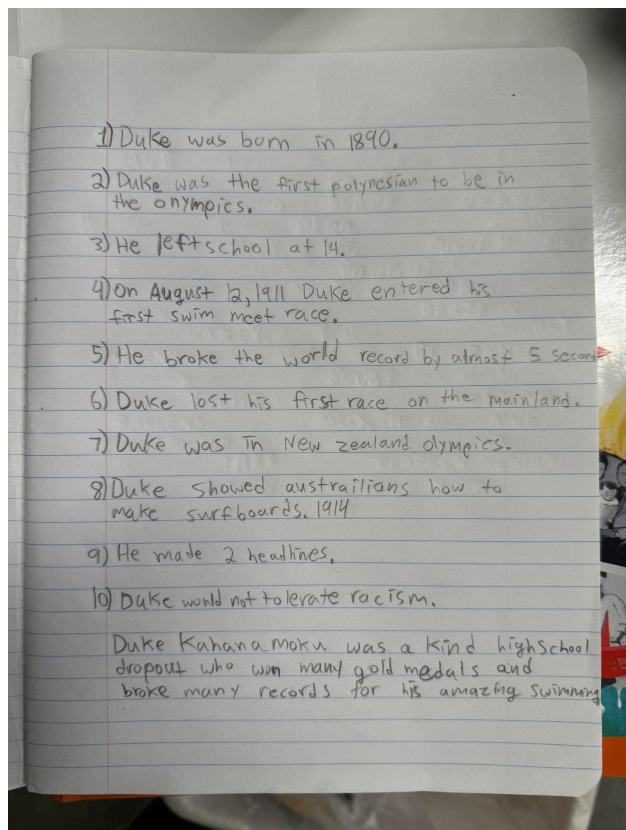
Module 8 Student Evidence

Module 8 Student Evidence Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

In this lesson, I made modifications for students as part of practicing the habits of differentiation. These annotated photos of student work show the choices I made in order to differentiate to different cultural and cognitive needs.

Module 8: Student Evidence



You can include student evidence by cutting and pasting an image or text evidence, or by embedding a link to a video or image in your Google Drive.

Student Sample # 1

Provide evidence of students experiencing **Culturally Responsive Instruction**. (this can be in the form of an image or video)

→ Pictured here is a journal entry from a student who participated in watching a Hawaiian history documentary.

Explain what you did intentionally to ensure students experienced **Culturally Responsive Instruction** during this lesson.

→ Being residents of Hawaii, I need to find ways to bring our state's unique history and traditions into my classroom. A recently made documentary called Waterman serves as an excellent biography of the great Duke Kahanamoku, whose life is a wonderful example of Aloha and determination. I chose this lesson as a form of differentiation for students

who were advancing more quickly through the course material; when students were complete with their independent writing task as described above, they would then begin watching the video and completing the notes on their own.

How could indicators of **Culturally Responsive Instruction** show up more in your classroom?

→ I currently don't own many books on the history of Hawaii. Our library comes from the book donations of mainland libraries. I have ordered some biographical books about Hawaiian legends such as Duke Kahanamoku

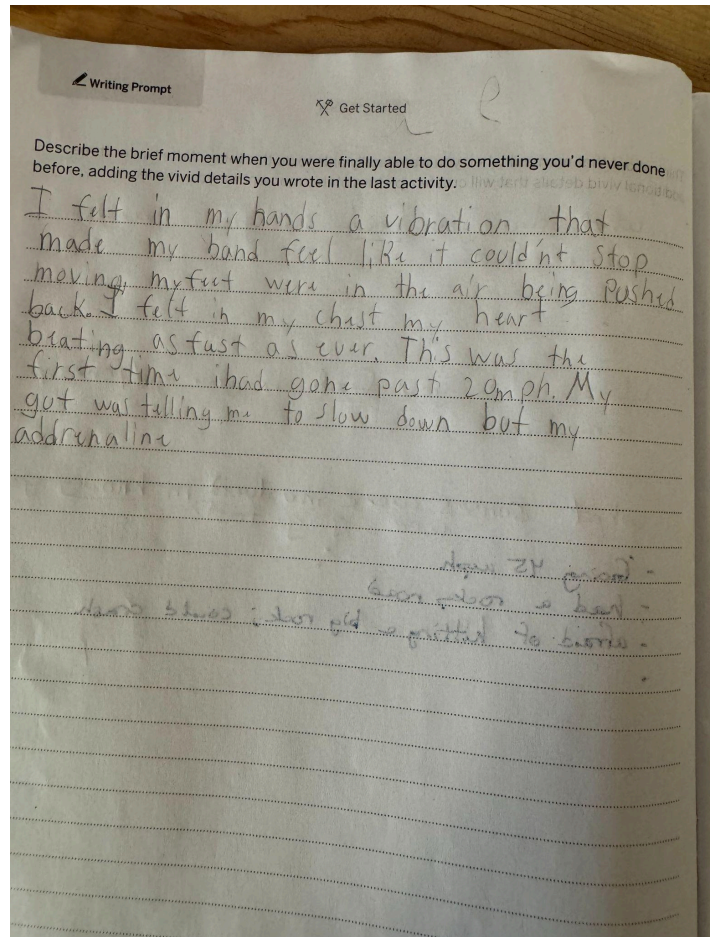
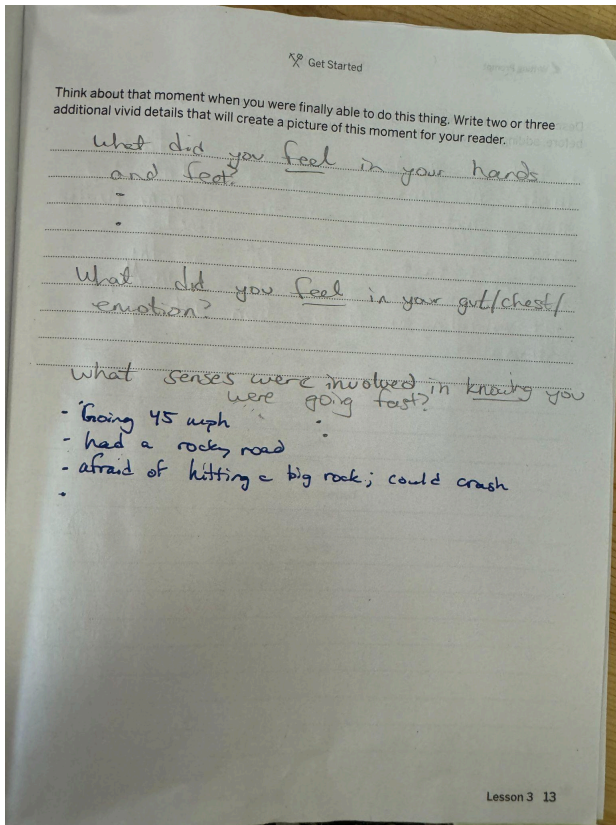
and Eddie Aikau. I think I could modify our textbook assignments to spend more time learning about Hawaiian history by replacing certain readings with others from our local library system.

How does this student evidence explicitly connect to what you learned in this module and how you are changing your practice based on the research?

→ My practice of allowing students to complete this assignment about a Hawaiian documentary fits with the research that shows that students respond better to educational material interests them. Apart from being Hawaiian, this documentary is extremely interesting in its own right. The fact that students who completed the textbook assignment were given additional work fits with the research that middle grades require many different levels of differentiation in order to reach all students while also not seeming like a “punishment” for finishing too early. If anything, this opportunity motivated all students to complete their textbook work on time.

Student Sample # 2

Provide evidence that students experienced instruction that considered their **Backgrounds** and/or **Special Needs**. (this can be in the form of an image or video)



Explain what you did intentionally to ensure students experienced instruction that considered their **Backgrounds** and/or **Special Needs**.

→ This particular student approached me in the previous lesson to say that he did not know what else to write. For this lesson which followed, I helped the student generate ideas for details he could add to his experience. First I wrote down questions for him to answer on his own. Then he began coming up with ideas verbally, so I wrote them down. The second image is his attempt at his revision. For comparison, his first entry was only one line long!

How could consideration of student **Backgrounds** and **Special Needs** show up more in your classroom?

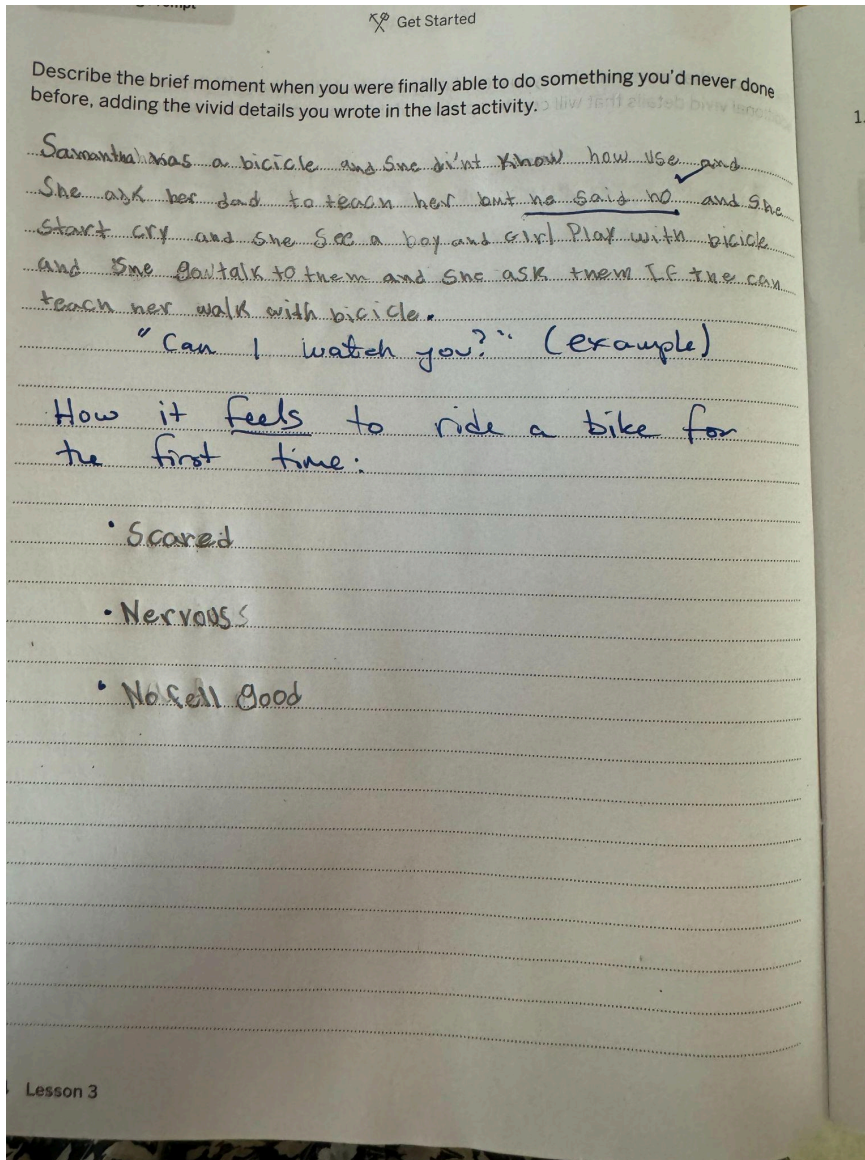
→ Not all students with learning needs can be helped at all times. I do have a teaching assistant who helps students, but I rarely come prepared with specific instructions on how she can help students. I think if I prepared notes about how to support students with their anticipated challenges, my TA would be able to help more of the students that I am not able to get to in any given moment.

How does this student evidence explicitly connect to what you learned in this module and how you are changing your practice based on the research?

→ This evidence reflects the improvements that can be made when instruction is differentiated to fit individual students' needs. By guiding a student through targeted questioning and personal dialogue for idea generation, I applied these principles to improve his engagement and attainment of learning goals in writing.

Student Sample # 3

Provide evidence of students experiencing **Personal Choice**. (this can be in the form of an image or video)



Explain what you did intentionally to ensure students had opportunities for **Personal Choice** during this lesson.

→ This is a work sample of an ELL student with less than two years of experience with English. The student hadn't written anything for 5 minutes after the writing focus period began, so I approached that student and asked if they needed help. The student told me that they would have an easier time of writing a fictional story rather than trying to revise their previous story. I allowed the student to write a fictional narrative as long as she tried to include details in her story.

How could **Personal Choice** show up more in your classroom?

→ I have limited seating options for students in my classroom. As a title I school in a rural zone of an island, our infrastructure is the limiting factor for many educational practices. I was able to secure a couch that was donated to me by a friend. However, I would like to have floor cushions, standing desks, and a wide bench covered by foam pads.

How does this student evidence explicitly connect to what you learned in this module and how you are changing your practice based on the research?

My writing on the page offered the student an alternative way to add detail to her writing passage without having to go through the cognitive rigor of re-writing her previous work. Her responses provided me with a quick and simple way to address this lesson with her in the next assignment.

Module 8 Reflection

1. How might you change your classroom instruction, engage with students for their learning, and/or assess students differently based on the learning from your Module 8 student evidence?

→ I plan to integrate more options for choice in my textbook lessons. I currently have students working at the same pace; volume of writing is the differentiation by default, and apart from that, additional improvised activities that act as “extra runway” for faster students have been my only differentiation for the upper performance levels. Adding more dimension to my differentiation by offering choice of format for our paper-based activities, such as using different media like paints or shaving cream or sticks to practice the spelling patterns, or non-writing storytelling methods such as speaking or skit-writing, can add optimal choices for students who have different curiosities and preferences. Introducing new formats like these can also improve retention of information due simply to their novelty as the frontal areas of the hippocampus are more activated when experiencing novelty.

2. Did you make any modifications to your initial lesson idea and/or would you make any changes to this lesson in the future? If so, what changes did/would you make and why?

→ I chose to give the ELL student the choice to write fictionally. I think I would rather have challenged her to re-write her previous story and sat with her while she did it. Because I offered the fiction option, I never got to learn exactly what part of the lesson she was struggling with; I could have supported her learning in a more targeted way by investigating it longer.

3. Describe the overall student learning and engagement with this lesson.

→ I was surprised by the high level of engagement in this lesson. I owe it in part to the fact that we are at the start of the school year and students have a lot of energy and desire to perform, but also, the use of a textbook rather than making the curriculum materials has freed up my own working memory and time in class to better focus on how students are understanding the material. I am able to spend more time differentiating activities in the moment when I notice students are struggling to catch on to the way I initially presented something.

4. What strategies related to **DIFFERENTIATION and CHOICE** did you implement? How did it impact the lesson overall? What would you do differently next time to implement **DIFFERENTIATION and CHOICE**?

→ I sat down with two students who were struggling and offered differentiation for both of them. One was an ELL student who did not accomplish the lesson goal of rewriting her story with sensory, action, or dialogue details. I offered her another chance at simply listing details about the feelings involved in the story she wrote, writing in her notebook to give clear and memorable guidance as I moved around the room to help others. I also offered her the choice to modify the prompt somewhat so that she could write about a story idea that she was more inclined to write about.

The other student writes very slowly, and I have noticed is more inclined to simply talk about his stories rather than write them down as words first. Over two class periods, I explained to him how we might make his journaling prompts more “dialogical” by having a conversation about the things he was writing about. In the second class period, he showed me his work and hadn’t written much, just like the first attempt. I began talking about what options he has to expand on the story, and midway through my talking, he began to speak about a memory he recalled that fit the prompt perfectly. I immediately took notes on what he was saying. When he was done, I showed him what I had written down and encouraged him to now turn them into detailed sentences. The

results were what I would consider a success because he went further than the words I had written down, going on to include details not previously discussed.

Post-Course Survey

Post-Course Survey Caption:

What is this document and its application of learning?

This post-course survey summarizes my thoughts on the course. It may serve as valuable feedback for the course instructors for future development of the curriculum.

1. As a result of taking this course, what is your current level of understanding of the neuroscience behind effective instruction?

Most of my knowledge of the neuroscience behind effective instruction came from outside of this course, but this course did help me think more clearly about how to implement those things in a systematic way.

2. As a result of taking this course, what habits might you now implement to establish a **friendly and welcoming environment** where students experience **choice, social support, and differentiation**?

Seeing as my resources are limited and I am still building up my faculties as a teacher, I think it would be wise to establish a rock-solid routine and set of rituals that students can get very used to expecting. Rather than re-invent the wheel with regard to the core of what I teach, I will take note of how my textbook already implements social support and differentiation (my Amplify ELA curriculum is great at both of these things). Adding choice will necessarily mean allowing students to write essay assignments about topics of their choice, because my classroom seating arrangements cannot be significantly diversified without a significant financial investment. I would like to introduce more fun and novel activities for learning the monotonous things, such as having a spelling bee with odd writing media, having “dictionary races” where groups compete to define words.

3. To what extent did you meet the goal you set for yourself at the beginning of the course? Please provide at least two examples of how you met your goal.

I did not create the slideshow like I had intended, but I did begin routinely instructing good learning habits to all of my students. One way that I do this is by enforcing a “focused writing time” of ten minutes rather than what I did last year of allowing students to use 40 minutes to work on an assignment at their own pace. This has led to improved quality of student writing, more productive class periods, and fewer “escape habits” like going for water breaks, chatting with peers, or bathroom breaks during work periods. I did this by setting ground rules for the writing periods, allowing students a minute to prepare for them each time, and circulating throughout the classroom with a TA while writing time is underway. This creates routine, safety, and focus.

Another thing I have implemented is explicitly telling students what the learning objective is for the day at the beginning of each lesson. Then throughout the lesson, I remind students of that objective, and I explain

what actions must be taken on the part of the student in order to accomplish the goals. For example, last week an objective was to be able to identify the three types of details of narrative writing, and the “how” was through focused, episodic writing that only detailed the events of one moment—something that happened in the span of ten minutes or less.